Ascertaining the Empowerment of Hevajra

Hevajrasyaṣekaniścaya · Toh 1272 · Derge Tengyur

དཀྱེ་པའ་རེ་རྫོགས་པའི་དབང་གཏན་ལ་དབབ་པ

Ascertaining the Empowerment of Hevajra, in Sanskrit the Hevajrasya Ṣekaniścaya and in Tibetan Gyepé Dorjé Wang Tenla Bappa, is a short verse treatise on the empowerment rites of the Hevajra tradition, attributed in its colophon to the great master Jitāri and translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Gayadhara and the translator Gyijo Dawé Özer. Drawing closely on the Hevajra Tantra, it sets out the preparation of the maṇḍala, the preliminary rites for the disciple, the vase empowerments with their verses and mantras, and the higher secret and wisdom empowerments, and then explains the four joys and four moments, the inner heat of caṇḍālī, and the experience of great bliss, closing with how the teaching may be given to monastics and others. It is Toh 1272 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of tantra commentaries, among the ritual and explanatory works associated with the yoginī tantra Hevajra.

In the language of India: he vajrasya ṣekaniścaya nāma. In the language of Tibet: Ascertaining the Empowerment of Hevajra.

Homage to the Blessed One, glorious Heruka.

Bowing to the hero, lord of knowledge and the knowable,
The all-pervading lord who bears the wheel,
I shall explain the supreme reality of empowerment,
The utterly stainless dharmadhātu.

Free from the worldly concerns,
Loving and without pride,
In accordance with the dispositions of beings
The Victor taught the outer activities.

Who is able to devise
The maṇḍalas exactly as they are?
Through union with one's own chosen deity
One should devise the maṇḍala of accomplishment.

And so it is said:

It may be made with the finest colored powders,
Or else with middling ones;
With powder made of the five precious substances,

Or else with the flour of rice and the like.

In accordance with one's means
One should draw the maṇḍalas.
One who has wealth should confer the empowerment so;
One without wealth confers it upon a painted image.

When the maṇḍala is complete, the mantrin
Should consecrate the vases.
The disciple, kneeling with palms joined,
Should supplicate the guru:

"I am sunk in the mire of saṃsāra,
Without refuge: all-pervading lord, protect me!"
Placing his hand on the disciple's crown,
The guru blesses him with mantra.

He sets the seed syllable of the wrathful one in the heart,
And should imagine the host of wrathful ones issuing from it
Devouring the heaps
Of the disciple's wrongdoing.

Having tied a protection cord on his hand,
He has him chew a tooth stick as well,
And, as a means of knowing his dreams,
Has him lie down on a bed of kuśa grass.
Whatever he sees, auspicious or inauspicious,
He reports just so to the guru.
If it is inauspicious, a pacifying rite is done;
If auspicious, one says, "It is good."

If he is to take up the vows in their entirety,
He should be generated as a mantra body.
A dot of blood consecrated with mantra
Should be given on his forehead.
Then, seated before the maṇḍala,
The master of yoga should himself enter.
Having covered the disciple's face with a cloth,
He should lead him into the maṇḍala.
With faith he bows to the maṇḍala,
And especially to the guru.

Whatever commitments of eating and of guarding have been taught,
Those commitments should be given to him.
Then, having circumambulated,
He should duly present the four gifts.
A flower consecrated with mantra
Should be cast onto the excellent maṇḍala;
By the place where the flower falls
His family should be known.
Having removed the disciple's face covering,
One should show him the maṇḍala itself:
"Purified as aggregates, sense sources and elements,
Having suchness as its very self:
To this yoga of the deity's form
You, my son, should apply yourself."

With the water of all the eight vases,
Which are one's own consorts and their male partners,
Meditating intently on the vajra of compassion,
One empowers the disciple who bears the vajra.
Meditating intently on the vajra sun,
One should give him the crown.
Joined with the vajra verses,
Everything is given as before.

For the disciple in the worldly attire of empowerment,
With the great nine-pronged vajra
Endowed with twenty-eight deities
One should confer the vajra empowerment:
"With the empowerment of the buddha vajra
Today you are empowered.
This is all the buddhas themselves;
To accomplish it fully, hold the vajra."

Meditating on the disciple as Paramāśva,
United in embrace with Tārā,
The lord of the vajra empowers him,
And should ring the vajra bell:
"Lord of the twenty-three deities,
With the bell I empower you."

oṃ vajra adhipati tiṣṭha vajra samaya stvaṃ

Meditating on the disciple as Vairocana
United in embrace with Locanā,
Placing the vajra and bell upon his head,
One confers the vajra name empowerment.
oṃ vajra satva tvaṃ abhiṣiñca mi vajra nāma abhiṣeka ta
"O, you are called Vajra such-and-such."

Whatever appears,
All of it is the emanation of the mind.
Phenomena are pure by their nature.
This mode of the buddhas' wisdom,
This, belonging to all the buddhas,
Rests in the hand of Vajrasattva.
You too should always hold it,
Steadfast in the discipline of Vajrasattva.
oṃ sarva tathāgata siddhi vajra samaya stvaṃ dha ra ya mi hi hi hi hi hūṃ

The rite of all accomplishment
Is worshiped by all the unsurpassed ones.
Then, from hand to hand by the vajra hand,
The vajra discipline is given to you.

The being without beginning or end,
Vajrasattva, the great joy,
Samantabhadra, the self of all,
Vajra pride, the lord of lords:
The bell that has arisen from the perfection of wisdom
Should be given to him.
"Called the vajra bell,
It accomplishes the benefit of all beings.
This, of all the buddhas,
Is said to follow the melody of wisdom.
You too should always hold it:
The Victors esteem it as supreme awakening."

Having bestowed every assurance,
Since I myself have become Śākyamuni,
Today, disciple, I make this prophecy for you:

Without doubt you will become a buddha.
You will be deathless and free from sorrow;
Neither fear nor fever will arise for you.
Through this vehicle of great bliss,
My son, I have made this prophecy for you.
Vajrasattva, the Tathāgata,
In order to purify existence completely,
Has drawn you out of the lower realms of existence.
Your prophecy shall be declared:
"On the face of the earth and in the heavens
You will become the Tathāgata
Called Hevajra."
"This is the commitment of the precious empowerment,"
So the Blessed One has said.

One born of the five supreme families
Should be placed there as the consort;
Or else whoever is available,
Likewise sixteen years of age.
For as long as the fluid is present,
For so long one should rely on the mudrā.
The face of the mudrā should be covered,
And likewise the face of the method partner.
Whatever arises from that union
Should be placed with thumb and ring finger
Into the disciple's mouth,
Together with this verse:
"Just as the noble buddhas
Empowered the children of awakening,
So I, with the secret empowerment,
Empower you through the stream of mind."
This is the secret empowerment.

She who is fair of face and wide of eye,
Adorned with a youthful form,
The wisdom consort born of the limbs of absorption,
Should be entrusted to the disciple.
For this there is the following verse:

"The goddess, giver of joy, giver of abode,
Of varied form, delighting the mind:
Take her, take her, great being,
And having taken her, make offering in full."

Knowing the yogas of one's chosen deity
And the union of wisdom and means,
With the mind settled deeply in equipoise
One should worship the mudrā according to the rite.
Endowed with wisdom and free of avarice,
He enjoys the moments of joy.
Then, bowing to the guru,
He should tell what he has experienced.
Then the Teacher, who knows the divisions of the moments of joy,
Gives the explanation:
"Listen as I explain the full knowledge of the three bodies,
The wisdom that is the nature of reality.

That which has the fair form of the syllable e,
Adorned at its center with vaṃ,
Is the ground of all bliss,
The jewel casket of the buddhas.
Divided by the divisions of moments,
The moments of joy arise there.
Moment wisdom and bliss wisdom
Rest fully in e vaṃ.
Variety and maturation,
Consummation, and likewise freedom from characteristics:
Through these the yogin who knows e vaṃ
Correctly arrives at the four moments.
Variety is explained as of many kinds:
Embracing, kissing and so forth.
Its reverse is maturation,
The enjoyment of the wisdom of bliss.
Consummation is declared to be the thought,
'I have enjoyed bliss.'
Other than these three is freedom from characteristics,
Which abandons both passion and passionlessness.
The first joy is variety;

Supreme joy is maturation;
The joy of cessation is consummation;
Coemergent joy is free of characteristics.
The master, the secret and the wisdom empowerments,
And the fourth as well, are likewise.
Through the division by the number of the four empowerments
Joy and the rest are to be known in order.
For this reason the joys
Are set out in four distinctions,
Because the four kinds, the coemergent among them,
Belong to the side of the completion stage.
The first joy is the hero;
Supreme joy is the yoginī;
Utter joy is all of them together;
Through the means of that bliss one knows all.
Joy is slight, yet it is great bliss;
Supreme joy surpasses it;
The joy of cessation is free of passion;
The remaining one is coemergent joy.
The first is the desire for touch;
The second is the desire for bliss;
The third is the abandoning of passion;
Through the fourth one should meditate.
Supreme joy is said to be existence;
The joy of cessation is nirvāṇa;
The middle is mere joy;
The coemergent abandons all of these.
Like the sky, free of dust and peaceful,
The supreme self of entity and nonentity,
Means and wisdom intermingled,
Passion and passionlessness blended:
That itself is the life of living beings,
That itself is the supreme imperishable syllable.
This reality, pervading everything,
Abides throughout the whole body.
By caṇḍālī blazing at the navel
The five tathāgatas are burned,

And Locanā and the others are burned too;
Through this burning, the moon-syllable haṃ flows down."

kolla ireṭṭha abola
mummuṇire kakkolā
ghaṇa kṛpiṭa ho bājja i
karuṇi ki a i na rolā
tahiṃ bala khājja i
gāḍheṃ ma a ṇā bijja i
hale kāliñjara paṇi a i
dundura bājji a i
ca u sama kasthuri sihlā
kāsbura lā i a i
māla indhana śāliñja tahiṃ
bharu khā a i
phreṃ khaṇa khaṭa karante
śuddha aśuddha na muni a i
niraṃsu aṃge caḍāvi
tahi jasarāva paṇi a i
māla aje kundurupāṭa i
ḍiṇḍama tahiṇḍa bājja a i

Because great bliss abides at the crown,
The wheel of great bliss is the great multitude.
The bliss by which one dies here,
That bliss is called meditative concentration.
When great bliss is attained,
Through variety the moment is abandoned.
"Great bliss is to be held,"
So the guru tells the great being.
"This wisdom is exceedingly subtle,
A vajra essence, equal to the sky,
Free of dust, bestowing liberation, peaceful;
You yourself are your own father."
This is the full awakening of wisdom and gnosis.

The play of passion and the rest is not explained here.

Again Nairātmyā requested:
"Monks, nuns, the aged,
And likewise eunuchs and the rest:
How will these attain awakening?
Blessed One, please explain this to me."
The Blessed One declared:
"Following the former procedure,
The master grants the perfect empowerment:
The joy of cessation, the first, and the culmination of the supreme.
Then one should rely on gnosis.
With the thumbs and ring fingers
Of one's own right and left hands
The yogin should press
The two waves of enjoyment.
The gnosis born from that
Is like the passion of a young maiden.
This gnosis that is experienced,
How could it be the domain of words?
In it there is no beginning, end or middle;
It is neither existence nor nirvāṇa;
There is no self, and no other either:
This is the supreme great bliss.
At first, delusion comes to die;
At the end, she who bears the form of saṃsāra;
In the middle, the dustless and peaceful,
The all-pervading lord, where entity and nonentity are exhausted."
This is the full awakening of the dharmadhātu.

Through the distinctions of engaging to benefit
Beings of various inclinations,
The great Vajradhara, lord of means,
Has taught many means of accomplishment.
The way of mantra is to be kept hidden.
This path, or else another,
Should be explained to a person of faith
Who is deeply devoted to the guru.

The Ascertainment of Empowerment Compiled from the Yoginī Tantra Hevajra, composed by the great master Jitāri, is complete. It was translated, revised

and finalized by the Indian preceptor Śrī Gayadhara and the Tibetan translator Gyijo Dawé Özer.

Translator's Notes

• "The worldly attire of empowerment" renders the obscure line slob ma'i 'jig rten dbang cha byad; its sense is uncertain. Rta yi mchog is taken as the deity Paramāśva ("Supreme Horse"); since the disciple is paired with Tārā, the figure intended may be Amoghasiddhi under this epithet. The "eight vases" line is taken to mean that the vases are visualized as consorts and male deities; the syntax is compressed. The secret empowerment section describes the ritual union of master and consort and the placing of the resulting fluid in the disciple's mouth, as in the Hevajra tradition.
• The Indic song beginning "kolla ireṭṭha" is the Apabhraṃśa song of the gaṇacakra known from the Hevajra Tantra; it is left untranslated as written. "At the crown" reads thod (head, skull) for the written thos ("heard"), which makes no sense here. The phrase "the great multitude" (phal chen po) describing the wheel of great bliss is obscure. The line "the joy of cessation, the first, and the culmination of the supreme" is compressed and its exact sense uncertain. "Joy of cessation" renders dga' bral (viramānanda). The author's name dgra las rgyal ba is taken as Jitāri.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.